

COMRADES IN ARMS Yechury, right, with Pinarayi Vijayan at the CPI(M) party congress

CPI(M)

The More Things Change...

By Jeemon Jacob

Kerala being the only state where the CPI(M) retains any political weight, it was natural that a good deal of fanfare was witnessed as its 23rd party congress wound down in Kannur—the local bastion—on April 10. But red festoons aside, to say India's largest Communist party is at a critical juncture would be an understatement. Even so, the response to it broadly stuck to formula. Change and continuity could be thought of in, well, dialectical terms, but there was more of the latter on view.

For one, the party renewed its faith in Sitaram Yechury, 69, who gets a third term as general secretary. He had taken over from Prakash Karat in 2015—a time when India had moved decisively into the Modi era, not the most propitious for Left politics. Considered less of a puritan and more of a pragmatist, he was seen as one who could perchance rescue the party from its nadir by dialling down the strict anti-Congressism of the Karat years—those had ended with an abysmal tally of nine Lok Sabha seats in 2014. But a disastrous outing in alliance with the Congress in West Bengal in 2016 trimmed Yechury's leverage substantially on that front.

That brought the second element of continuity. The political resolution made the obligatory pledge to "defeat the BJP by organising all secular and democratic forces", but again, stated the party would eschew pre-poll alliances with the Congress. (Instead, it would accord centrality to regional parties, like the DMK.) This is yet another iteration of the line that's part of the CPI(M)'s genetic history—the party had formed after splitting from the united CPI in 1964 on precisely this point.

Yechury, chosen as gensec for the third term, has to deal with the paradox created by the Kerala unit's anti-Congressism

Yechury, in a sense, is trapped in a hard line he may not prefer but which is favoured by the Kerala unit—lorded over by the imperious Pinarayi Vijayan—which has the age-old war with the Congress in its marrow. (The paradox: supporting "regional" parties would inevitably bring up the question of its foe in Bengal, the Trinamool Congress, a claimant to being India's premier anti-BJP force.) So, the positive words about Yechury as a unanimous choice—that he "can deliver best in the current scenario", as a senior politburo member told INDIA TODAY—need to be tempered with a touch of realism.

As for change, it came in dribs and drabs. History of sorts was made when Dr Ram Chandra Dome, 63, a seven-time MP from Bengal, became the first Dalit ever in the 15-member politburo, the CPI(M)'s highest decision-making body. The news of course is that it took so long. Other new faces include Ashok Dhawale, president, All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS), a prime mover in the recent farm protests. The idea of focusing on livelihood issues has a certain traction. As Yechury said, "Prime Minister Narendra Modi is preoccupied with hijab and halal. We have to break this vortex by mobilising people's movements." A. Vijayaraghavan, the Left Democratic Front convenor in Kerala and another newly-minted politburo member, elaborates: "The BJP's attempts to undermine India's federal structure will only increase as it tries to execute its 'one nation, one party, one religion' agenda. Non-BJP-ruled states have no choice but to fight back. The party believes the fascist agenda will naturally offer a space for the Left to take a lead role in this."

Kerala state Congress chief and MP K. Sudhakaran pooh-poohs the ambitions of a party that got under 2 per cent of the vote share in 2019. "Who'll align with them? They have just three MPs in the Lok Sabha. Even Left parties like the RSP and Forward Bloc (FB) have snapped ties with them," he claims. Kerala is a showpiece for the CPI(M), but the dilemma is about whether to conserve what's left or to reimagine Communism for 21st century India. Aside: last week, FB even dropped the hammer-and-sickle from its flag. ■